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Juxtaposing Characters Skills for Navigating British Imperialism and Slavery

The effect that British imperialism and slavery has had upon the world is not just seen in real life, but also within texts. These texts often take different approaches when writing on the topic, often changing the story's point of view from the invader to those being invaded, or changing the acceptance people have when exposed to imperialism or slavery. *Nervous Conditions* by Tsitsi Dangarembga reflects on this topic by making its main character, Tambu, rely on the spoils of the British culture which have been brought to Rhodesia by her uncle Babamukuru, while coming to realize there is often more harm than good when combining the two opposing lifestyles of Europe and Rhodesia together. *The Secret River* by Kate Grenville has its main character, William Thornhill, being the executor of imperialism upon the Darug people of New South Wales, showing the act of colonizing from the colonizers perspective while also addressing the slavery which took place during the same time. Finally, *Lagoon* by Nnedi Okorafor opts for the opposite perspective of *The Secret River* by having its main character, Adaora, shelter an alien she names Ayodele while the rest of her species looks to occupy Lagos, hoping to live in peace with the largely unwelcoming community. Each of these stories have ideas which juxtapose one another, providing multiple points of views and feelings relating to British imperialism and slavery.

For a large section of the opening to *Nervous Conditions*, the life which Tambu lives in one which has not been tarnished by Imperialism. Living on her homestead with her nuclear

family, Tambu's life revolves around helping her family work their fields, and learning the heavy burden of womanhood (Dangarembga 32). Her brother, Chido, is the only member of her nuclear family who is exposed to Imperialism at the beginning of the story, due to Babamukuru. Being the only educated male in the family, getting a postgraduate degree from England (5) while his children were growing up, Babamukuru is often treated as the leader of Tambu's entire family, regularly sharing his wealth with Tambu's homestead and being a role model for the men in the family, and eventually Tambu as well. After the death of Chido, it was decided that there had to be a member of the household who was educated, and after much disagreement by her father, Tambu was eventually allowed to move to the mission where Babamukuru and his family live. It is from this point onwards in the story where Tambu is exposed to the malevolent side of Babamukuru, one that was built up from his time in England. When arriving at the mission for the first time, the lavish life that Babamukuru's family lives is made evident, and Tambu is entirely hypnotized by his greatness, stating "Babamukuru was God, therefore I had arrived in Heaven" (108). Her ethereal experience is quickly tarnished after spending time with Nyasha, Babamukuru's daughter, who sees through his facade and is often victim to his wrath, being beaten and shamed while she tries to readjust to the Rhodesian lifestyle. Nyasha tries to explain her difficulty fitting back to living in Rhodesia, telling Tambu "when you've seen different things you want to be sure you're adjusting to the right thing" (175). This is a burden placed on her by Babamukuru, one which caused a complete deterioration of Nyasha's life. After her time at the mission comes to an end by the end of the novel, it is clear that Babamukuru is not the man he was framed as in the story's beginning. This was a fact Tambu's mother was well aware of. "'It's the Englishness,' she said. 'It'll kill them all if they aren't careful,' and she snorted" (296).

In order to navigate the imperialism that has surrounded her life by Babamukuru, Tambu learned the important idea of separating the life that is made possible by Babamukru, and the life provided by her parents that she was raised to respect and never forget. Being able to see the death of Chido, the newfound abrasiveness of Babamukru, and misery of Nyasha allowed for Tambu to see the negative side of imperialism, the one which she never knew existed until living at the mission. “I told myself I was a much more sensible person than Nyasha, because I knew what could or couldn’t be done”(298). This was the method chosen by Tambu to navigate the world of British imperialism which was starting to surround her, “to question things and refuse to be brainwashed”(298). Unlike the characters in *The Secret River* and *Lagoon*, Tambu was able and willing to free themselves from imperialism for some time, and could see both the positive and negative effects of its presence. William Thornhill, however, would not be so willing to avoid being brainwashed.

The Secret River follows the life of William Thornhill and his family when they are forced to live in New South Wales after Will was exonerated from his crimes in London, England. Much like the opening to *Nervous Conditions*, *The Secret River* does not focus on imperialism nor slavery until a fair length into the story, with Will discovering what will eventually become Thornhills Point. Once the Thornhill’s have established their home in New South Wales, they begin to realize they have unexpected neighbours living on their hundred acres of land. This land is already occupied by the Darug people, so the arrival of men like Will, Smasher Sullivan, and Thomas Blackwood is akin to British imperialism being spread across their land. As opposed to *Nervous Conditions*, the perspective of the protagonist exists in those spreading their beliefs and practices, rather than being exposed to it. One act carried out by Will in effort to instill his English ways on the Durag people is by trying to make them speak English.

He partly succeeded in the effort, getting two Durag people he named Jack and Long Bob to say their own names, yet they still filled their sentences with their own dialect. This was partly insulting to Will, but “a man who could write his own name, William Thornhill, along a piece of paper, could not be made to look a fool by a naked savage”(Grenville 214). By the end of the novel, Will turns out to be successful in teaching another Durag man, Jack, how to speak more fluent English, as he is the only Durag man living on Thornhill’s Creek. This turns out to be due to all other Durag people being wiped out of the area around Thornhill’s Creek, with Jack being the only one left, a prisoner forced to learn his jailers language. “Sal had taken him on as something of a project. A penance, it had occurred to Thornhill”(327). This, however, is not the only moment of imprisonment in the novel. When Will visits Smasher Sullivan to inquire about buying dogs from him, Will receives an invite inside of Smashers hut. Within a dark corner of this hut, chained and near a mattress, was a Darug woman.

A black woman, cringing against the wall,
panting so he could see the teeth gleaming in her pained mouth,
and the sores where the chain had chafed, red jewels against her
black skin.(251)

Unlike his willingness to displace the Durag people for his family's sake, and ambition to teach them the English lifestyle, Will strongly opposes the idea of slavery. This view on slavery is one shared amongst all three protagonists in the aforementioned novels. Other than an old white lady making reference to child labor and slavery when Tambu is selling mealies(Dangarembga 49), there is no direct exposure of Tambu to slavery, with the selling of her mealies being her own choice in hopes of earning enough money to further her education. Adaora and her peers were fostering Ayodele all while she was in Lagos, but at no point was

there a decision to keep her as a slave, cementing her aversion to slavery as well. Will's approach to navigating British imperialism when only compared to Tambu, however, is quite the inverse to her own. Where Tambu sees the negatives of the British impact on people's life, Will sees the positive. Tambu was able to see the frightening self-absorption of Babamukuru shatter the health of Nyasha and his own composure, frightening her from being exposed to Englishness and learning that it was not the perfect way of life as she thought as a youth. Will, on the other hand, only viewed his imposing of Englishness upon the Darug people as helping them. Although doubting himself at times, such as his vocal declaration to participate in the massacre of the Darug people "sound[ing] like another man's, more sure of itself than his own could be"(299), he still allowed himself to participate in these crimes, regardless of knowing they were likely the wrong thing to do. Even when the Darug people are removed from the area which is then called Thornhill Point, no remorse is felt, only fear that someday they may come back to take what is theirs. Tambu navigates the British imperialist space with caution and knowledge, while Thornhill creates this space which forces people like Babamukuru and Tambu to either sink or swim.

Finally, the British imperialist navigation techniques of Adaora must be navigated, a skill set which resembles Tambu's more so than Will's. In *Lagoon*, Adaora and those living in Lagos play the role of those being invaded by a more advanced species. This could, in the interest of comparing this story to the others, be seen as British imperialism taking over the Lagotian space. This invasion begins with Ayodele joining the group of Adaora, Agu, and Anthony together in the interest of using their powers for good, eventually getting their assistance in amassing a crowd in front of Adaora's house in order to let the others of Ayodele's species to integrate seamlessly into the crowd. The newfound presence of these aliens in the crowd replicates the

action of British imperialism seeping into foreign lands and the people that occupy it, much like William Thornhill and the other white men in *The Secret River* occupying the land along the Hawkesbury River. Between the two stories, there is an equal reaction by those who originally occupy their land. In Lagos, the majority of the residents are against letting the aliens occupy their communities, with many trying to kill the aliens without success due to their self replicating abilities. On the Hawkesbury river, the Darug people were less quick to try and kill their invaders, but quickly left signs that they were not welcome. In both stories, the invaders are not thrilled by these attempts of self-defence. The quotes “‘I hate humans,’ Ayodele said... ‘I want nothing to do with you,’ Ayodele continued. ‘Any of you.’” (Dangarembga 136), and “He felt something hot in his chest: anger? Or was it fear? He wished he had the gun” (Grenville 196) exemplify the frustration felt by the invading forces when they realize they are not wanted. There is a clear lack of want on both sides. Those who already occupy their space do not want unwelcomed people trying to live amongst them, and these people intruding the land do not appreciate their arrival being retaliated against.

Regardless of how the others in Lagos are acting, Adaora does not join in their protest, opting to smuggle Ayodele around in hopes of restoring peace to Lagos and allowing for the aliens and humans to live harmoniously. Unlike the unsuccessful attempts of the Darug people trying to live with their colonizers, the Lagotians found success with help from their President, asking his people to “listen to your own hearts and look around” (Okorafor 279), a request which was not shown to receive backlash. In regards to navigating the British imperialist space which surrounded her, Adaora took the change in stride, being an advocate for letting the aliens join their society. Much like Tambu, she took an educated stance on the matter, choosing to let the proof of what Ayodele is capable of guide her decision rather than casting judgment immediately

upon discovering they were an alien. Adaora also did not look to enslave Ayodele nor any alien they were aware of, matching the behavior of William Thornhill, but not the similar in guilt Smasher Sullivan. *Lagoon* contained similarities to both *Nervous Conditions* and *The Secret River*, but was different in how the two groups of Lagotians and the aliens were eventually able to get along, instead of one side permanently hurting the other for its own interest.

All three characters in the discussed novels have their unique ways of navigating British imperialism and its effects on their life, with some traits aligning and others being vastly different. Tambu opted to deal with the consequences of imperialism by trying not to ignore its presence, while making sure to benefit from its handful of positive values in order to make others aware of the negative impact Britain had caused and is currently causing in Rhodesia. William Thornhill abused his control of imperialism in New South Wales by ridding the Hawkesbury River of the Darug people, occupying land that never belonged to him and killing off those who lived on the land long before the Thornhill's arrived in Australia, although never sinking to the levels of Smasher Sullivan by participating in the slavery practice. Adaora also did not involve herself with slavery, but also did not attempt to kill the aliens invading Lagos, opting to help them integrate into her community. Adaora took the best traits of Tambu and Will, and even though she was a member of the population being invaded, she chose to use intelligence over mob mentality, allowing for Ayodele and the other aliens to be treated as her equals. These three characters' approaches to dealing with both British imperialism and slavery ultimately juxtapose one another, showing that there is no right way to handle either situation, but rather that the best way is the one that feels most right to them.

Works Cited

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